

Swift Star

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COVER STORY

Damon and Baby: hands-on with the ridiculous twin-stick shooter, out March 26

Arc System Works and Executive Director Daisuke Ishiwatari are known for fighting games, and their upcoming game, Damon and Baby, is a huge shift.

Phil Hornshaw · PlayStation Blog

It's an action-adventure game that's defined by an overhead viewpoint, twin-stick shooter mechanics, a light-hearted, cartoonish art style, and a wry, satirical wit — a departure from series like Guilty Gear and BlazBlue.

Damon and Baby is an expansive game that packs a surprising amount of depth and challenge. I recently played through the first 10 hours of Damon and Baby ahead of its release to get a first-hand feel for its blend of action mechanics and comedy stylings.

You take on the role of Damon, a demon with aspirations for greatness, who has what turns out to be an unfortunate friendship with a priest. At the start of the tale, the priest shows up mortally wounded and entrusts Damon with a baby. Little does Damon know that, through supernatural shenanigans, the two have become inseparable, and if Damon wanders too far away from the baby, he's instantly teleported back to her.

Stuck with putting his demonic plans on hold to care for a cute child, Damon sets out to find a way to separate himself from the baby. But he quickly discovers that while he wants to get rid of the kid, there are demonic forces, led by Death, who will do anything to claim her. And while Damon is a curmudgeonly demon, it turns out he has a heart of gold, so he grabs some guns and sets about fighting through hordes of supernatural enemies.

Each of the gun archetypes comes in all sorts of variations, sporting different stats and nuanced capabilities. Some guns might add additional bullets to their spread, pierce through enemies, or fire in powerful, short bursts rather than continuously.

Each weapon is good for specific situations, encouraging you to change them up often as you fight all kinds

of enemies. From easily-defeated knife-wielding spirits, to giant, flying, shield-wielding fiends, there's a huge number of threats to deal with and you'll have to constantly shift strategies in order to stay alive.

Damon and Baby gives you a few interesting tools to help you, as well. Before long, Damon realizes he can use that whole baby curse thing to his advantage, giving you the ability to throw the baby, which causes Damon to teleport to wherever she is and catch her. That move allows you to cover big gaps that you couldn't normally jump over, and it serves as your primary dodge to escape enemy attacks.

Even normal enemies can be huge and powerful, but the bosses take things up a notch — like a giant, katana-wielding wolf dressed like he belongs in Kill Bill, or a moth who uses a massive sniper rifle against you in a grocery store. They'll clobber you if you're not on your game.

Throwing the baby is also just one of the many abilities that help you explore its sprawling areas. As Damon earns a double-jump and wall jump, and "ultimate" abilities that let him do things like smash through certain kinds of objects, you can revisit earlier areas to discover secrets and power-ups, or earn money for buying new weapons. Damon and Baby's levels are huge, and offer almost as many nooks and crannies to check as demons to shoot.

The thing I liked most in my preview of the game, though, was Damon and Baby's comedic sensibility. It's set in a world where demons, angels, and monsters are old hat for normal folks, and dealing with Heaven and Hell

is mostly a bureaucratic annoyance, and it's a paperwork snafu that costs Damon his powers at the start of the game.

Damon's ultimate goal is to get to Sedona — as in, Arizona — and he's helped out by a demonic insurance agent, a vampire mafioso who transforms into a bat to help you in combat, and an angelic cook, among other weirdos.

It's a game that imagines a goofy supernatural world that's full of spirits and creatures trying to help you save the world, but who still have to work within a society full of mundane tasks and arbitrary rules. The absurdity leads to a lot of good jokes, especially as Damon complains his way through the journey.

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FRONT PAGE

The Sunday Papers

Mark Warren · Rock Paper Shotgun

Sundays are for deciding to re-watch The Sopranos. Specifically that episode in which Tony gets a bad tummy and then talks to a fish. You wonder what you might fever dream of, if you too were to go and eat at an Indian restaurant, then have enough room for a snack at Artie Bucco's fine Italian eatery? Would you too dream of surreal wandering down a boardwalk? Would you instead dream something different? Would you dream of a platypus sitting in a high-rise apartment, looking up from the newspaper as he reminds a house guest not to trip over a potted cactus when they exit his bathroom?

Would that be the-Oh. Oh no. It's happening again. The person who's emerged from the bathroom, tripping over the plant on the way, is bald and reeks of alternative comedy. Ready the words and prepare to fire.

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FEATURES

Achieving Test Reliability for Native E2E Testing: Beyond Fixing Broken Tests

Jin Kim · Docker Blog

End-to-end (E2E) tests are particularly important for native applications that run on various platforms (Android/iOS), screen sizes, and OS versions. E2E testing picks up differences in behavior across this fragmented ecosystem.

But keeping E2E tests reliable is often more challenging than writing them in the first place.

The fragmented device ecosystem, gaps in test frameworks, network inconsistencies, unstable test environments, and constantly changing UI all contribute to test flakiness. Teams easily get trapped in a cycle of constantly fixing failing tests due to UI changes or environment instability rather than improving the overall reliability of their test infrastructure. They end up frustrated and hesitant to adopt E2E tests in their workflows.

Having led the native E2E testing infrastructure setup at a mid-sized company, I learned the hard way how critical it is to define and implement strategies for test ownership, observability, and notifications in ensuring long-term test stability. In this piece, I discuss the challenges I've seen teams face and share lessons on how to build reliable E2E systems that you actually trust.

After setting up periodic E2E runs on the CI, our team initially focused on triaging, investigating, and fixing every failing test to improve test stability. However, even after nearly a year of patching flaky tests, the reliability of our E2E suite didn't improve, and engineers slowly lost confidence in the usefulness and reliability of the test suite.

I learned that teams that focus primarily on fixing broken tests often end up in a cycle of chasing failures without fixing the root causes of instability. This reactive approach creates several problems:

Test suite fragility : If teams continue patching broken tests without addressing real issues with either the underlying app changes or unstable environments, the test suite becomes increasingly brittle. Over time, tests fail for reasons unrelated to real product defects, making it harder to distinguish genuine regressions from noise.

High maintenance overhead: Debugging and fixing flaky tests often requires a significant amount of developer time and resources. Unlike unit tests, which run quickly and fail in isolation, E2E tests execute against the development, staging, or pre-production environment, making failures harder to reproduce and diagnose. Adjusting E2E tests to work across devices with different screen sizes or OS versions requires additional work, making fixes a non-trivial task.

Reduces trust in the test suites: When failures are common and noisy, teams lose confidence in the E2E suite, and they often start ignoring test failures. This undermines the purpose of having automated tests in the first place. Instead,

teams rely on local dev testing or manual QA cycles to validate changes. Over time, the suite becomes more of a liability than a safeguard, slowing down delivery instead of enabling it.

A reactive approach to fixing E2E tests slows down release cycles. Developers must spend significant amounts of time repeatedly fixing and rerunning failing tests, while teams rely on manual QA to catch actual regressions.

When our test suite stability didn't improve after more than a year of chasing failures, we took a step back to analyze historical results and look for patterns.

We discovered that a significant number of failures could be attributed to an unstable environment or an unexpected state of the test account. For example, spikes in API latencies in the test environment frequently caused false negatives, adding to the noise. Similarly, tests run against existing user accounts could become inconsistent due to a past failure or if multiple tests attempted to use the same account.

I learned that investing in improving your test infrastructure is the only way to get to a stable and reliable native E2E testing workflow. This involves stabilizing the test environment, defining clear test ownership, reducing noisy alerts, and improving observability. Let's look at each of these in more detail.

Many flaky E2E tests can be traced back to inconsistencies in the underlying environment, such as sporadic device issues, network instability, or API downtime in a staging environment.

To avoid noisy and unreliable tests, ensure you have a stable and standardized test environment with the following test practices:

Standardize device and environment setup: Device and test environment stability issues heavily impact test stability. To reduce API downtimes, isolate the E2E testing environment from the developer or staging environment to prevent interference from unstable builds and experimental features. Teams could either build a stable pre-prod environment that uses a production-ready artifact or spin up ephemeral environments for each E2E run to ensure consistency. Running tests on standardized device images or containerized emulators with consistent OS versions, configurations, and resources further improves stability. For critical flows, you can schedule periodic runs on physical device farms to validate against real hardware while keeping day-to-day tests stable and cost-effective.

Isolating test data per session: A test that makes modifications to any data should start from a clean slate. For instance, while testing a todo application, every test session should use a new test account to avoid unexpected scenarios because of unpredictable account state. To speed up tests, execute setup scripts in `before` hooks to handle account creation, and seed any required data automatically.

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How architects design airports to handle superlong security lines

Nate Berg · Fast Company Design

The historically long security lines currently snaking through U. S. airports are the painful result of extreme circumstances. Callouts, no-shows, and resignations by Transportation Security Administration workers fed up with a lack of pay during a partial government shutdown, combined with a bump in spring break travelers, have created unusually congested airport security checkpoints.

For the architects and airport authorities that work together to design these heavily regulated spaces, it's the kind of convergence you can't exactly plan for. But, according to some of the designers of these spaces, airports are increasingly incorporating design features that can help them manage extreme security lines in the future.

George Bush Intercontinental Airport (IAH) in Houston
[Image: Stantec, in collaboration with Grimshaw]

The lines, though currently caused by TSA worker shortages, are actually governed by the airports themselves and therefore are the airports' problem. "There are regulations, but what the TSA is really interested in is the point from where you have your last document checked, called the TDC, to the actual [scanning] equipment," says Ty Osbaugh, principal and global aviation leader at Gensler, a design and architecture firm. "That's their land. How the queue works is purely up to an airport."

How big that queue gets, though, is out of the airports' and their designers' hands.

Controlling the lines leading up to the security checkpoint takes a lot more than setting up a maze of stanchions. Osbaugh says airports carefully plan their pre-security, or landside, spaces to manage flows of passengers that can vary wildly during different times of the day and different days of the year. Building flexibility into this area, which can often share space with ticketing areas, allows for the lines to adapt to the crowds and circumstances.

Gensler is currently working on a \$9.5 billion redesign of Terminal 1 at John F. Kennedy International Airport in New York City, and Osbaugh says the landside space was designed with softer edges to be able to accommodate overflow. "We've got a garden that's [adjacent], so if the queue starts to back up—God forbid that it does—now people have that extra space to be able to queue instead of backing into the ticketing areas and everything," he says.

Other airports, including some currently experiencing incredibly long security lines, don't have this kind of flexibility. "That's the problem that we see in Hartsfield right now," Osbaugh says, referring to the Hartsfield-Jackson International Airport in Atlanta, where travelers have been advised to expect four-hour wait times. "The checkpoints are boxed in by hard elements on both sides. So it's just trying to figure out how do you have that pressure relief valve in the queue?"

IAH Airport [Image: Stantec, in collaboration with Grimshaw]

Airports are designed with epic security lines in mind, but that doesn't mean they are built around the chance that they occur. Jonathan Massey, managing principal and aviation sector leader at the architecture firm Corgan, says his firm's approach is to understand the existence of outlier events, but to design for more realistic peaks. "You always know something's going to happen. There's going to be a snowstorm somewhere, there's going to be a strike, there's going to be a terrorist event, there's going to be a pandemic," he says.

Osbaugh, who's been designing airport projects since before the September 11, 2001, terrorist attacks, recalls a time when the security screening was an agent waving a metal detecting wand.

Nate Berg

Airports rarely end up being large enough to handle abnormally high crowds that may only occur once every few years. Massey says airports are designed to accommodate predictable peak surges like spring break, the summer travel season, and Thanksgiving. "We'll look at those as our planning baseline. Things like pandemics, strikes, government shutdowns, blizzards—those fall outside of that," he says. "Typically, the industry just isn't willing to spend \$1,000 a square foot to make a building bigger for what might happen."

Airports can also be hesitant to try to solve unpredictable crowding problems in facilities that will stand for decades, especially as new security technologies are rapidly changing the checkpoint process. Osbaugh, who's been designing airport projects since before the September 11, 2001, terrorist attacks, recalls a time when the security screening was an agent waving a metal detecting wand. "The one thing that is constant, and will continue to be constant as it relates to security checkpoints, is they are going to evolve," he says.

When it begins opening in phases later this year, the new Terminal 1 at JFK Airport will integrate biometric document-checking technology that could, one day, eliminate the need for human workers to manually check identification and boarding passes. "It's taking the need of staffing for airlines down to next to none, but it's also reduced the footprint of how much space is needed at a check-in hall," Osbaugh says. The lines leading up to this checkpoint, he adds, can "accordion" in size depending on the size of a crowd at any given time.

Such flexibility has some architectural implications. Jeff Mechlem, airport sector leader at the architecture and engineering firm Stantec, says it's become more important for airport designs to have wide open areas for the entire security pipeline. "[We're] looking to make sure we can reduce

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standard-article(title: [I was the untitled goose in Big Walk, the balmy new open world co-op puzzler from House House], author: [Edwin Evans-Thirlwell], source-name: [Rock Paper Shotgun], images: (), paragraphs: ([House House were kind enough to keep a video of my hands-on session with Big Walk , filmed by one of the participating PRs. Generally, a full video of a preview event including player audio is a lifesaver for a journalist, struggling to keep notes while pushing buttons. But in this case, I don't want to watch the Big Walk video, because then I would hear what the other players were saying when I wasn't there.], [You see, I fell down a cliff midway through Big Walk, and spent the night floundering about in the ocean. Eventually, a developer armed with a big, ball-shaped lamp tracked me down and ushered me back up, hoisting me onto his shoulders so that I could leap to a rock. Nights in Big Walk last moments. I was gone for the length of a luxurious toilet break. But still, those were moments in which the others were gathered, waiting for me. Perhaps they were making fun of me. I don't want to know.], [Read more],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 171, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

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ANALYSIS

standard-article(title: [Slay the Spire 2's 'anti-infinite' balance patch has now itself been patched, much to the relief of some Silent and Necrobinder players], author: [Edwin Evans-Thirlwell], source-name: [Rock Paper Shotgun], images: (), paragraphs: ([Slay the Spire 2 developers Mega Crit have rolled back aspects of last week's big STS2 balancing update , which nerfed a number of cards according to the broad objective of making infinities – that is, cunning combos that let you prolong your turn forever - harder to accomplish.], [The patch in question isn't even formally part of the roguelite deckbuilder yet – you have to opt into the Steam beta branch to test it out. But it has sparked a ruckus nonetheless among the Spire Slayers, some of whom attempted to review bomb the game despite Mega Crit's protestations that Slay the Spire 2 is still in early access development .], [Read more],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 114, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

IN BRIEF

Mark Warren, Rock Paper Shotgun: Right, roll call time. “A barbarian (for all the bonk boys in the audience)”. Present. A mage who’s the smartypants choice. Yeah. A thief, who’s both “classic” and “obligatory”. Here. “Rat with saxophone”. Yup. Right, that’s all of the fantasy trope character types accounted for in *Dark Scrolls*, a roguelike dungeon-running platformer from the devs behind *Gunbrella* and *Gato Roboto*.

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ScienceDaily, ScienceDaily: Using a smartphone with long nails can be frustrating, forcing people to awkwardly tap with their fingertips instead of their nails. Now, researchers are working on a clear nail polish that could change that by turning fingernails into touchscreen-friendly tools. By experimenting with dozens of formulas, they discovered that combining common compounds like taurine and ethanolamine can help nails carry just enough electrical charge for screens to detect a touch.

Robert Purchase, Eurogamer: Hello and welcome back to our regular feature where we write a little about the games we've been playing. This week, Bertie discovers he's not as good at Slay the Spire 2 as he would like to be; Connor continues to fall to the Dark Side and embrace his inner troll; and Marie realises that older games really were more challenging.

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Victoria Phillips Kennedy, Eurogamer: Turns out it is not just studios and live-service projects which are party to Sony's cancellation spree, as last night, it was announced that the PlayStation Remote Play-enabled car known as Afeela 1 has also been nixed.

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Last Week in AI, Last Week in AI: Anthropic releases Sonnet 4.6

Related:

Claude Sonnet 4.6 model brings ‘much-improved coding skills’ and upgraded free tier

Claude Sonnet 4.6 delivers frontier-level AI for free and cheap-seat users

Anthropic releases Claude Sonnet 4.6, continuing breakneck pace of AI model releases

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James Archer, Rock Paper Shotgun: Perhaps sensing competition in the field of Japan-flavoured arcade racing games, Forza Horizon 6 devs Playground Games have revealed the open-world vroomer's system requirements. Agreeably, they're a sensible balance of attainable low-end fare – at 1080p, a GTX 1650 and 16GB of RAM are apparently all that's needed for 60fps – and the kind of hulking graphics bricks that you'd expect for 4K ray tracing. Only the most baby-oiled of hypercars for the RX 9070 XT owners, you understand, though support for lil' handhelds like the Steam Deck is confirmed as well.

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Manuviraj Godara, MakeUseOf: I had tunnel-visioned myself into using Acrobat for everything PDF-related, from reading to highlighting. It was as if I was justifying the cost by using the program. But, as it turns out, Firefox already had all the PDF manipulation features I needed. Also, seeing Adobe's business practices, I'm better off without their tools, especially considering that the free version of Acrobat Reader is practically a running advertisement for Adobe's paid features.

Fran Ruiz, Eurogamer: Dragon's Dogma 2 was a very special RPG even if some its bones could've used more work and the New Game Plus loop span its wheels without extra end-game content to give it juice. Still, like the original , it gained a dedicated following, so it's not surprising to read two years later folks asking for a Dark Arisen -like DLC. Now, Capcom has celebrated its second anniversary, but we're left with nothing but disappointment once again... or are we?

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Last Week in AI, Last Week in AI: China's Moonshot releases a new open source model Kimi K2.5 and a coding agent

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Moonshot AI unveiled Kimi K2.5, an open-source, natively multimodal model trained on 15 trillion mixed visual and text tokens that understands text, images, and video. The company emphasizes strong agentic capabilities, citing “agent swarm” orchestration where multiple agents ...

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Connor Makar, Eurogamer: Warframe 's next update - The Shadowgrapher - is fast approaching. A shot in a new direction for the sci-fi MMO, players will have to navigate through cramped corridors and inky pathways in the game's first explicitly horror-inspired game mode. But how exactly do you make a game with bullet jumping and space ninjas scary ?

Read more

Victoria Phillips Kennedy, Eurogamer: Microsoft has announced its next Xbox Partner Preview showcase will take place later this week, and focus on third-party games from the likes of Sega and GSC GameWorld. [View full article on Eurogamer](#)

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